

Borrowed Pulpit

How closely FBC Tucson’s 2026 “A Church of Irresistible Influence” series tracks Alistair Begg’s *A Study in 1 Thessalonians*

27%

of the senior pastor’s sermon words sit inside near-verbatim Begg passages
six sermons in the 1 Thessalonians series, sermon body only

6 of 6

sermons by the senior pastor map one-to-one onto a same-titled Begg sermon
the two sermons by other preachers: 0%

0

mentions of Alistair Begg or Truth For Life in any of the nine transcripts
119 borrowed non-Scripture elements catalogued

Executive summary

Six of the nine FBC Tucson recordings are sermons by the senior pastor (“Pastor Pat”) in a 1 Thessalonians series. Each one is a re-delivery of Alistair Begg’s sermon on the same passage, usually under Begg’s own title, with about a quarter of the sermon’s words falling inside near-verbatim Begg passages and the outline, illustrations, commentator quotations, closing lines and even closing prayers carried across. The two sermons preached by other FBC staff on the same book show no Begg material at all.

27%

of sermon-body words in reused regions

8,943 of 32,920 words; 25% after removing Scripture both men read

10–40%

range across the six sermons

Sexual Purity lowest; No Clever Tricks highest

8.5/10

median reviewer dependence rating

0 = independent, 10 = read aloud. Range 7–9; controls 0

13–43%

of each Begg sermon reappears in the FBC version

Begg’s 4,021–6,409-word sermons feed FBC sermon bodies of 4,665–6,656 words

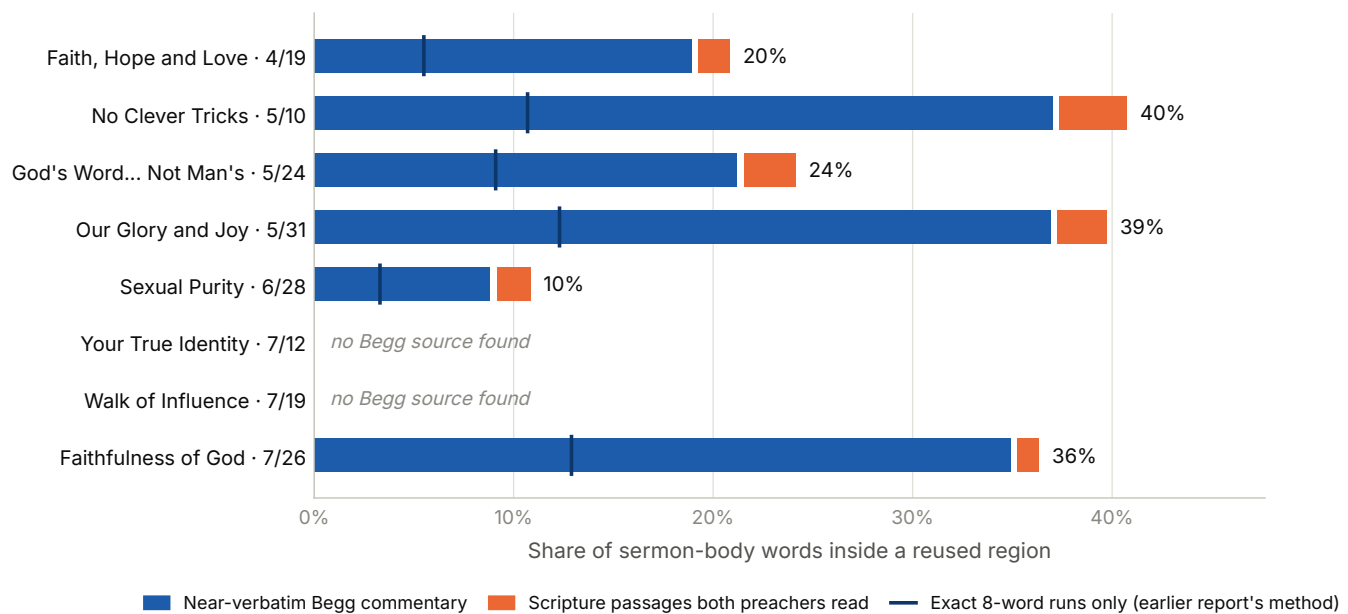
Key findings

1. The pattern is consistent across all six sermons. Every one of the senior pastor’s six sermons pairs with exactly one Begg sermon, the one on the same verses, and with none of the other 21. Overlap with the paired sermon runs 7% to 21% of the full livestream transcript against a ceiling of 1.8% for any non-paired Begg sermon and 4.4% for Begg reusing his own material across his own series (Exhibits 2 and 3).
2. The earlier report understated it by roughly seven-fold. Counting only exact eight-word runs, and dividing by whole-service transcripts of which a third to a half is songs and announcements, gave 3.7%. Aligning near-verbatim passages that caption errors and light paraphrase had broken, and measuring against the sermon itself, gives 27% (Exhibit 1).
3. Begg’s outline is the sermon’s skeleton. In all six sermons the reused passages march through Begg’s sermon in order (rank correlation 0.49 to 0.89), and the reviewer found the same headings, the same sequence of proof texts and the same closing lines in every pair (Exhibit 4).
4. What travels is the distinctive material. The reviewer catalogued 119 borrowed non-Scripture elements: 13 illustrations, 11 commentator quotations, 4 prayers, 5 wordplays and 18 structural devices among them. Four end on Begg’s closing line or peroration and a fifth on his closing prayer; two pray Begg’s closing prayer clause by clause and a third opens with his prayer over the text.
5. The borrowing is presented as personal. Begg’s “I found John Stott to be so helpful” becomes “I found John Stott, a great theologian, so helpful”; Begg’s confession about his own week is preached as the FBC pastor’s own week; “Parkside Church” becomes “FBC”; British tea becomes American coffee. Begg himself is never named.
6. The pattern is specific to one preacher. Pastor Kevin’s “The Walk of Influence” and an associate’s “Your True Identity”, on the same book in the same series, share only Scripture with Begg. They serve as the study’s natural control.

What this review is and is not. It establishes textual dependence from transcripts: what was said, in what order, and whether a source was named. It does not establish intent, and it does not assess whether Truth For Life’s usage terms permit re-preaching; those terms were not reviewed. Both transcripts are machine-generated, so word-level figures are floors rather than ceilings.

A tenth to two-fifths of each of the senior pastor's sermons is Begg, near-verbatim

EXHIBIT 1 Share of sermon-body words inside a reused Begg region, by sermon (chronological)



Source: YouTube auto-captions of FBC Tucson livestreams; Whisper transcripts of Truth For Life audio. Sermon body = reviewer-marked start and end of the sermon proper (excludes songs, announcements, altar call). Reused region = chain of exact 4-word seeds re-scored by token alignment, ≥ 12 words, $\geq 45\%$ identity. Scripture classification by reviewer, region by region.

Reading the exhibit

The blue bar is commentary: Begg's own sentences, illustrations and applications reappearing in the FBC sermon. The orange segment is Bible text that both men read aloud from the same translation and is not evidence of anything. The dark tick marks what the earlier report's method would credit: only unbroken eight-word exact runs.

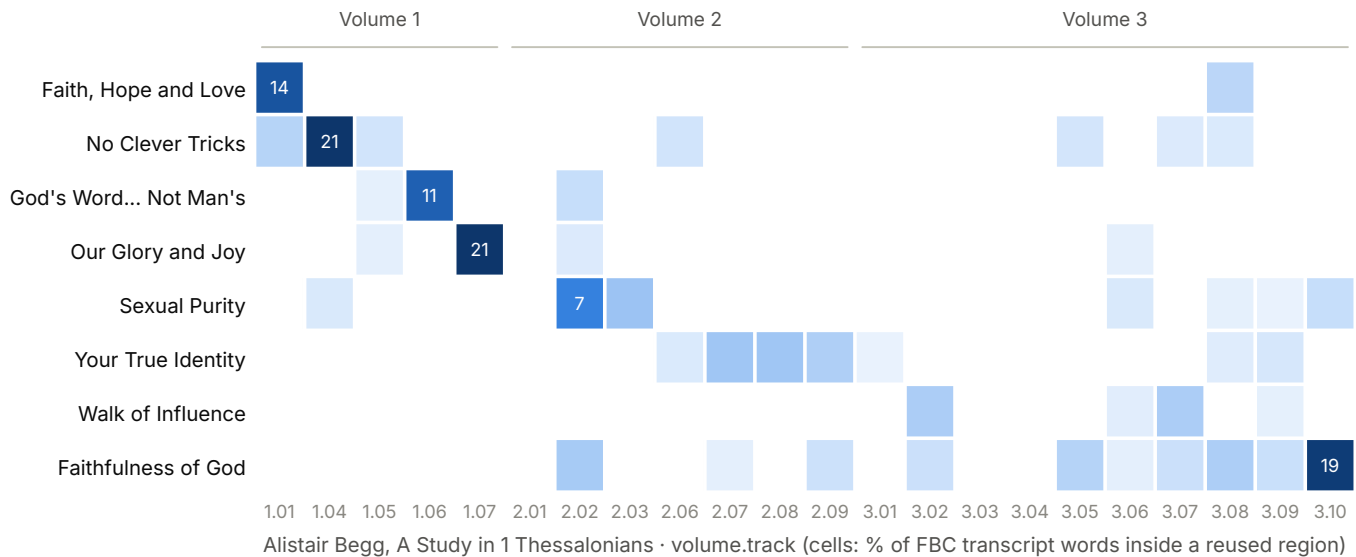
The two sermons by other FBC preachers register nothing. Their transcripts were scanned against all 22 Begg sermons with the same detector; the reviewers' independent n-gram sweeps found only Scripture.

Why the earlier figure was low

- Wrong denominator. The captions cover the whole service. Songs, announcements and the altar call are 33–55% of each transcript and contain no Begg.
- Brittle detector. Exact runs break at every caption error ("John Stodd" for Stott, "thorough affairs" for thoroughfares) and every Americanisation ("tea" to "coffee"). Word-weighted identity inside reused regions averages 61%, so most borrowed passages never form an eight-word exact run.
- Still a floor. Reviewers flagged whole borrowed paragraphs the aligner missed (e.g. the "speaking freely, openly, fearlessly" word study in No Clever Tricks) and structural borrowing it cannot see (the 20-minute dialogue device in Sexual Purity).

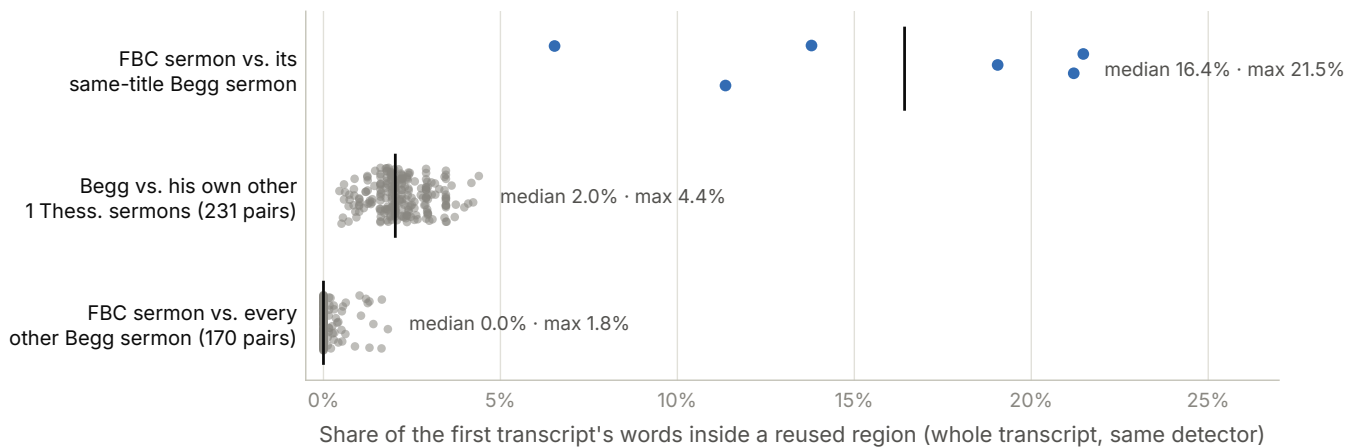
Each sermon maps onto exactly one Begg sermon, at three to ten times any natural overlap

EXHIBIT 2 Reused-region coverage of each FBC transcript against all 22 Begg sermons



Source: as Exhibit 1. Cell value is the share of the full FBC transcript (not just the sermon body) inside a reused region with that Begg sermon; cells $\geq 3\%$ labelled. Volume 1 covers 1 Thess. 1–2, Volume 2 covers 4–5, Volume 3 (“Reminders for the Local Church”) covers 5:12–28.

EXHIBIT 3 Natural overlap between preachers on the same book is small; the paired sermons are not

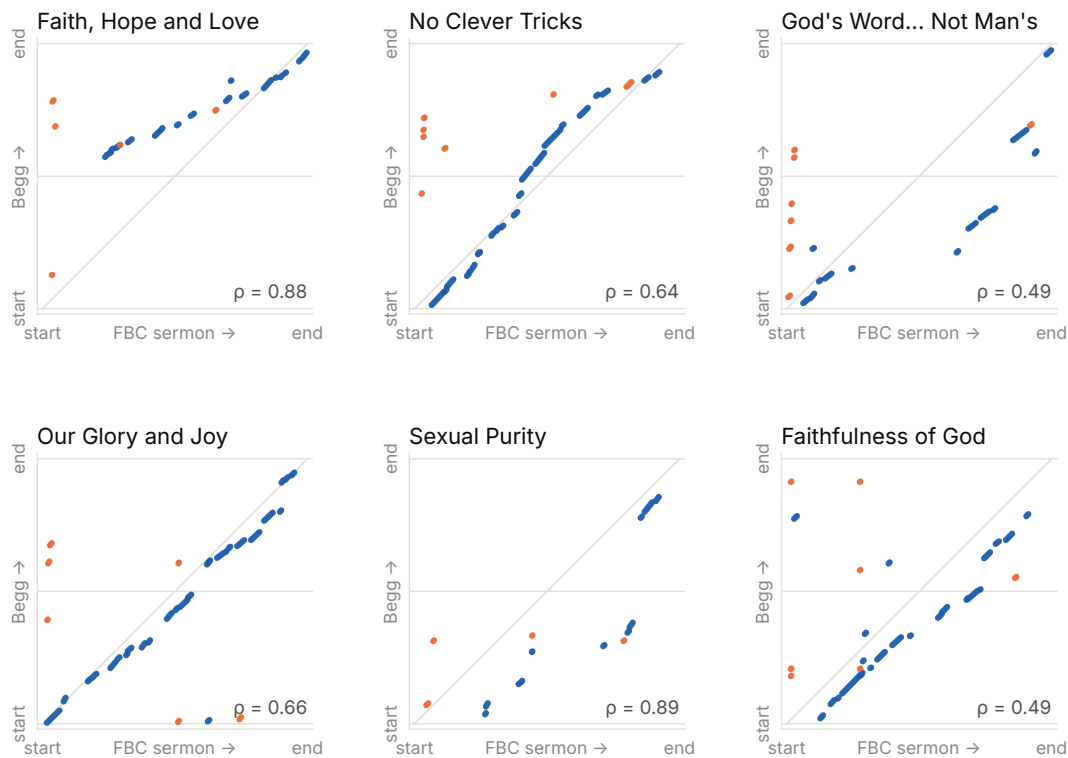


Source: as Exhibit 1, whole-transcript basis for comparability. Begg-vs-Begg: all 231 pairs of his own 1 Thessalonians sermons, capturing a preacher's normal self-repetition. FBC-vs-other: the 170 FBC/Begg pairs that are not the same passage.

Two things stand out in the heat map. First, the diagonal: each FBC sermon lights up only the Begg sermon on its own verses. The faint cells elsewhere (1–2%) are Begg quoting the same benediction across his series, or shared Bible readings. Second, the rows for Your True Identity and The Walk of Influence are as faint as any non-paired cell even though Begg preached the same passages (Volume 2, Parts 1–3; Volume 3, tracks 1–9). Two men preaching the same verses independently produce about what those rows show, which is the baseline the six paired sermons exceed three- to ten-fold.

The sermons follow Begg's outline from beginning to end, consuming up to 43% of his text

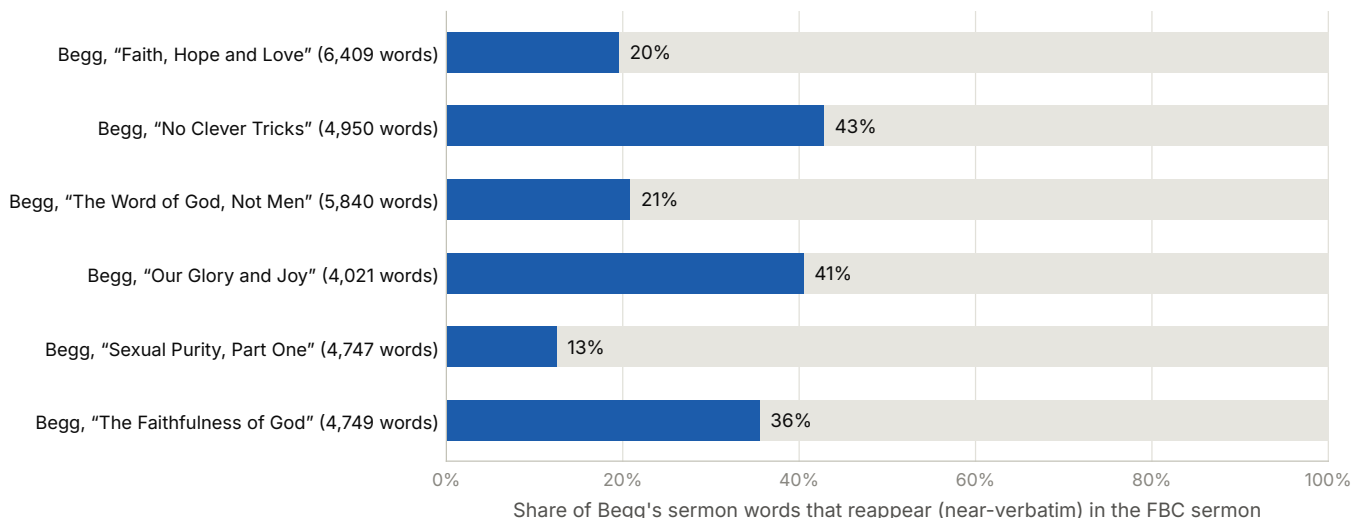
EXHIBIT 4 Where each reused passage sits in the FBC sermon (x) and in Begg's sermon (y)



Source: as Exhibit 1. Each mark is one reused region, drawn from its start to its end; blue = commentary, orange = shared Scripture. A mark on the diagonal means the passage occurs at the same relative point in both sermons. ρ = Spearman rank correlation of positions.

A preacher who consulted Begg for a few ideas would produce scattered marks. Instead the marks form staircases: the FBC sermon proceeds through Begg's sermon in Begg's order, and the flat stretches are the pastor's own insertions (a Mother's Day frame, a Barna survey, a 13-minute prayer appeal) between Begg's points. Above the diagonal (Faith, Hope and Love) he skipped Begg's opening; below it (Sexual Purity) he added a long opening of his own before joining Begg's text.

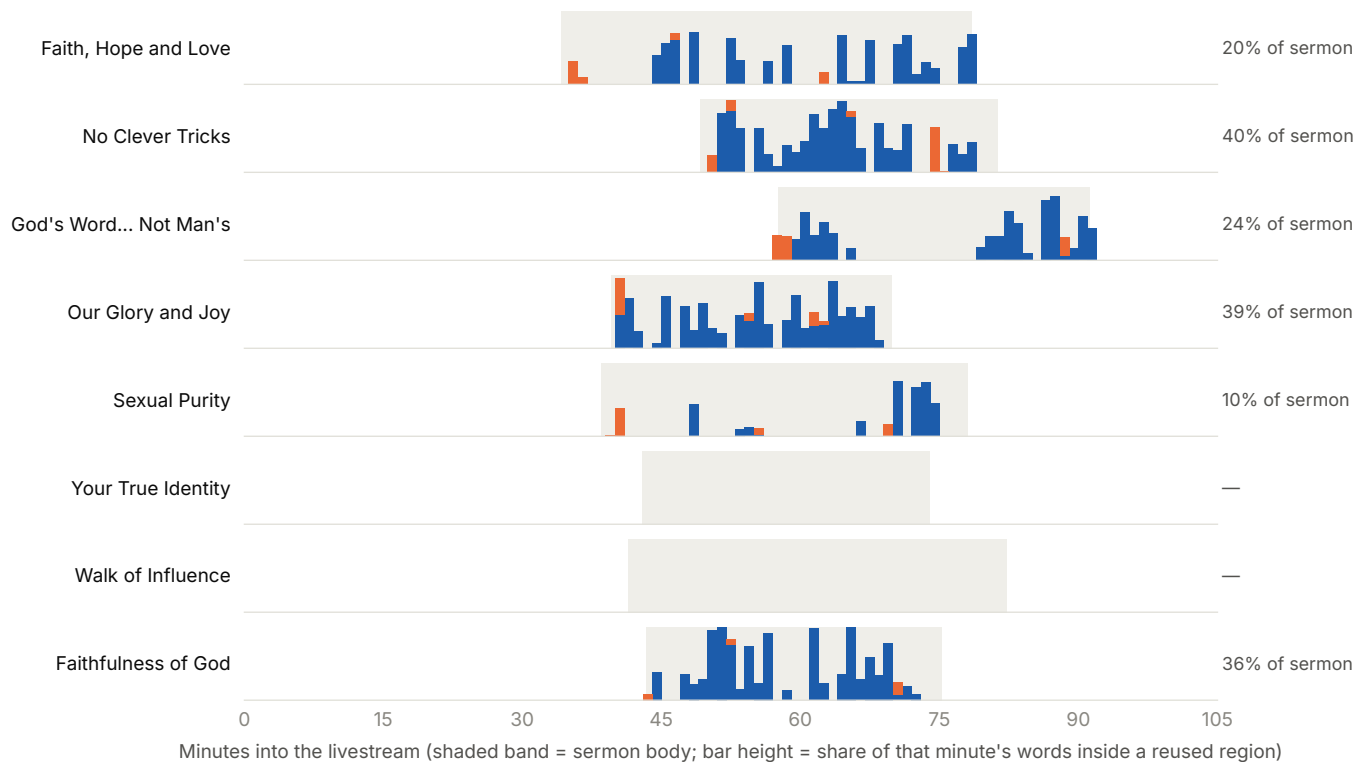
EXHIBIT 5 Share of each Begg sermon's words that reappear near-verbatim in the FBC sermon



Source: as Exhibit 1, source-side coverage. Begg's paired sermons are $\{\min(s[\text{'tokens'}]) \text{ for } s \text{ in } \text{SRC.values}() \text{ if any}(s[\text{'key'}]) \text{ in } r[\text{'paired_sources'}] \text{ for } r \text{ in PAIRED})\}; -\{\max(s[\text{'tokens'}]) \text{ for } s \text{ in } \text{SRC.values}() \text{ if any}(s[\text{'key'}]) \text{ in } r[\text{'paired_sources'}] \text{ for } r \text{ in PAIRED})\};$ words; the FBC sermon bodies are $\{\min(r[\text{'body'}])[\text{'tokens'}]) \text{ for } r \text{ in PAIRED}\}; -\{\max(r[\text{'body'}])[\text{'tokens'}]) \text{ for } r \text{ in PAIRED}\};$ words.

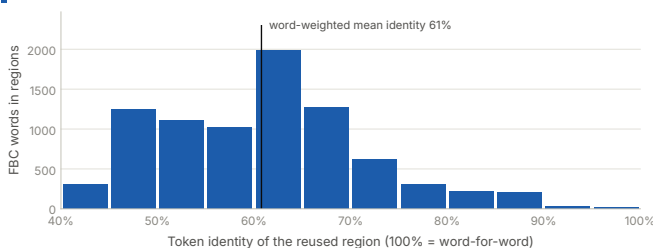
The reuse is spread through the whole sermon and delivered as light paraphrase

EXHIBIT 6 Minute-by-minute share of words inside a reused region, across each livestream



Source: as Exhibit 1. Shaded band marks the reviewer's sermon start and end.

EXHIBIT 7 Token identity of non-Scripture reused regions, weighted by length



Source: as Exhibit 1. Identity = matched tokens ÷ region length after alignment.

Not read aloud, but not rewritten either

Verbatim reading would cluster identity near 100%; genuine re-composition from notes would leave little that aligns at all. The distribution sits in between, centred on 55–70%. That is the signature of a manuscript being paraphrased as it is spoken: word order kept, connectives kept, nouns and idioms swapped for local ones.

The longest single reused region outside the pure Bible readings runs 361 words (The Faithfulness of God, from the Zinzendorf hymn through the Phillips rendering of verse 24; Begg's commentary interleaved with the verses he quotes). The longest unbroken exact run is 31 words. Across the six sermons the detector found 151 reused regions, 115 of them commentary rather than Scripture.

Roughly 58 of the 212 minutes the senior pastor spent preaching these six sermons were spent inside a Begg passage.

What travels is the distinctive material, and it is re-voiced in the first person

Borrowed elements catalogued by the reviewers

TYPE	COUNT
Exegesis	32
Application	18
Structure	18
Illustration	13
Commentator quote	11
Transition	9
Quotation	8
Wordplay	5
Prayer	4
Joke	1
Total, six sermons	119

Each element is a non-Scripture item the reviewer judged too specific to be coincidence or shared stock phrasing, quoted with timestamps in the review files. Scripture read by both preachers was excluded before counting.

Attribution

Sermons naming Alistair Begg	0 of 6
Sermons naming Truth For Life or Parkside	0 of 6
Any "I heard a preacher say..." hedge	0 of 6
Begg's named authorities kept	Stott, Morris, Packer, Phillips, Lewis, Zinzendorf
Begg's anonymous "one commentator" kept anonymous	2 sermons

Six ways the borrowing is personalised

1. Second-hand reading presented as first-hand. Begg: "again I found John Stott to be so helpful." FBC: "I found John Stodd, a great theologian, so helpful." Begg: "to notice this little driving phrase in Paul's life." FBC: "It took me a while to dig up this phrase in Paul's life."
2. Begg's life becomes the pastor's life. Begg: "that's been true this week. It has for me. I have not lived and done all the good for which I longed." FBC: "that's been true this week. At least for me ... I haven't done all the good that I long to do." Begg's eleven years since leaving Scotland becomes 37 years since Little Rock.
3. Church names swapped, sentence kept. "If people came from other churches to imitate Parkside Church, what would we give them to imitate?" becomes the same question about Fellowship Bible Church, followed by Begg's four-item answer.
4. Britain becomes Arizona. Tea to coffee; cinema to movie; "wee bit over the top" to "reading it over the top"; "the devil" to "the enemy"; Begg's Sunday-evening markers to Sunday morning.
5. Statements become call-and-response. "The source, the force and the course" becomes "the source. Say that with me." Begg's "God is for us" becomes "Now, let's say it out loud. God is for me."
6. Even the prayers are borrowed. Two of the six closing prayers follow Begg's prayer clause by clause and a third sermon opens with Begg's prayer over the text, including the rare phrase "the thoroughfares of our lives", captioned at FBC as "thorough affairs".

FBC TUCSON 1:01:47	ALISTAIR BEGG
"I like to quote from one commentator where he says this in Thessalonica. There's probably never been such a variety of religious cults and philosophic systems as in Paul's day. Now again, this commentator is writing before the late 20th century. You know what? I think that our culture might be able to rival that."	"Let me quote from one commentator. There has probably never been such a variety of religious cults and philosophic systems as in Paul's day. This was written before the late 20th century. We might be able to rival it now."

No Clever Tricks. The pastor reproduces not only Begg's anonymous quotation but Begg's act of quoting it and his dating aside, recast as a personal habit.

SERMON PROFILE 1 OF 6 · APRIL 19, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 1:1-3

“Faith, Hope and Love” *tracks* Begg, Volume 1, “Faith, Hope and Love”

20%

of sermon words in reused regions
19% commentary · 2% shared Scripture

20%

of Begg's sermon reappears
1,256 of 6,409 words

8/10

reviewer dependence rating
order correlation $\rho = 0.88$

40%

estimated original material
reviewer estimate of the sermon

From verse 1 onward the sermon is Begg's exposition re-delivered: the same headings, the same anonymous commentator, the same Pennsylvania etymology, the same closing tagline and a closing prayer that follows Begg's clause by clause. Begg's 25-minute Acts background is dropped and replaced with a 2026 Barna survey opener.

Outline comparison

Same skeleton, minus Begg's long Acts 16-18 travelogue. From the moment the FBC preacher reaches 'here we move into chapter 1, verse one' [00:43:48] to the final 'Amen' [01:18:35], the sequence of ideas is Begg's, point for point and in Begg's order: Paul-means-little (Chrysostom, Thecla, Eph 3:8, Isa 66:2) → Silas/Sylvanus/Pennsylvania and Timothy → ekklesia and 'no buildings' → Father and Son plus the Spirit → grace and peace, Saul of Tarsus, fountain-and-stream, the junkie → the three causes of thankfulness in Begg's headings ('the work which ...

What is the pastor's own

The FBC preacher replaces Begg's entire 25-minute Acts 16-18 historical background with a contemporary-research opener, and he substitutes his own illustrations at most of Begg's illustration slots while keeping Begg's exegetical skeleton, headings, phrasing and closing prayer. The original content is almost entirely (a) the Barna worldview-survey introduction, (b) sports/pop-culture illustrations, (c) local and personal references, and (d) heavy ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 1:07:00

“this labor of love, you know what we tend to do? We tend to think of it as a little thing like, “Oh, yeah. I uh I cut the grass for the lady next door. Uh it's nothing at all. Just a labor of love. Or you know, I brought my spouse a cup of ...”

Two invented domestic vignettes reproduced in the same order with the same repeated punchline. The lone change is the drink (British tea to American coffee). Nothing in 1 ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“We tend to think of a labor of love as a little thing. You know, oh, I cut the grass for the lady next door. Oh, it's nothing at all. It was just a labor of love. I bring my wife a cup of tea in the morning says the husband, it's nothing ...”

FBC TUCSON 1:16:59

“when they think of the people at FBC, what do we want them to think about? We want them to see a faith that functions, a love that labors, and a hope that endures. And I know God has much to say to us these five chapters.”

The sermon's closing tagline with only the church name swapped (Parkside for FBC) and one alliterative verb changed, followed by the identical next sentence about the five ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“they may think of Parkside Church... and they may say when I think of that place, I think of a faith that functions, I think of a love that labors, and I think of a hope that hangs on. And in God, I know God has much to say to us through ...”

FBC TUCSON 1:17:30

“Oh Lord, how proper it is to be rightly envious of this church. Oh God, could we become better acquainted with this kind of working faith in increasing measure? Lord, we want to be prepared to labor to the point of weariness, fatigue, and ...”

Begg's extemporaneous closing prayer is prayed back almost clause for clause, with 'rightly jealous' softened to 'rightly envious'. A borrowed prayer cannot be explained by ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“Oh, Lord, we're rightly jealous of this church. We want to know this kind of working faith in increasing measure. We want, Lord, to be prepared to labor to the point of wearingness, fatigue, and perspiration... And we want, Lord, not to ...”

Sermon body 0:34:14–1:18:35 of the livestream (44 min, 6,656 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

SERMON PROFILE 2 OF 6 · MAY 10, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 2:1-8

“No Clever Tricks” *tracks* Begg, Volume 1, “No Clever Tricks”

40%	43%	9/10	30%
of sermon words in reused regions	of Begg's sermon reappears	reviewer dependence rating	estimated original material
37% commentary · 3% shared Scripture	2,121 of 4,950 words	order correlation $\rho = 0.64$	reviewer estimate of the sermon

The closest tracking in the series. The sermon follows Begg from its first sentence (“Romans reveals his mind, 1 Thessalonians reveals his heart”) to its peroration (“no seminary can ever make a pastor ... only God can do that”) without leaving his sequence, reproducing even Begg’s act of quoting an unnamed commentator and his dating aside.

Outline comparison

Same skeleton, in the same order, down to the sub-points. Both open with the identical 'Romans reveals the mind / 1 Thessalonians reveals the heart' framing, both then detour to Acts 17 for the birth of the church, both reconstruct the same imagined slander ('he ran away, didn't he?'), both then walk the identical three-part division (vv. 1-2 honest assessment of the visit / vv. 3-4 present appeal / vv. 5-6 past approach, flagged by the change of tense), both pause at the same word studies (dokimazo with 2 Timothy 2:15; kolakia as a New Testament ...

What is the pastor’s own

The FBC preacher adds a Mother's Day frame at the front and back, a substantial expansion of the Jonathan Edwards illustration, several long personal stories from his own marriage and ministry, and contemporary American application. None of Begg's structure is displaced by this - the original material is inserted between Begg's points rather than replacing them. The biggest genuinely independent stretches are (a) the Mother's Day framing and the ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 1:01:47	ALISTAIR BEGG
“They’ve been the huers. I like to quote from one commentator where he says this in Thessalonica. There’s probably never been such a variety of religious cults and philosophic systems as in Paul’s day. Now again, this commentator is writing ...”	“Now in addressing himself in this way, Paul is distancing himself from the many itinerant vagrants whom he also knew had been working the crowds. Let me quote from one commentator. There has probably never been such a variety of religious ...”
The clearest single proof. FBC does not just reuse Begg's anonymous quotation - he reuses Begg's own act of quoting it, and Begg's parenthetical dating of it, while recasting ...	
FBC TUCSON 1:02:17	ALISTAIR BEGG
“holy men of all creeds and countries, popular philosophers, magicians, astrologers, crackpots and cranks, the sincere and the spurious, swindlers and saints, they jostled and they clamored for the intention of the credulous and the ...”	“holy men of all creeds and countries, popular philosophers, magicians, astrologers, crackpots and cranks, the sincere and the spurious, the righteous and the rogue, swindlers and saints, jostled and clamored for the attention of the ...”
An eighteen-word alliterative catalogue plus the reaction line that follows it, essentially word for word. This is not Scripture and is far too idiosyncratic to be ...	
FBC TUCSON 1:18:13	ALISTAIR BEGG
“the truth of the gospel is so significant and so immense and so profound that no seminary can ever make a pastor. That no church can ever make a pastor. Only God can do that.”	“The task of the gospel is so significant and so immense and so profound that no seminary can ever make a pastor. No church can ever make a pastor. Only God can do that.”
The sermon's peroration - the line the congregation is meant to remember - is Begg's, verbatim apart from 'the truth of the gospel' for 'the task of the gospel'.	

Sermon body 0:49:12–1:21:22 of the livestream (32 min, 5,196 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

SERMON PROFILE 3 OF 6 · MAY 24, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 2:13-16

“God's Word... Not Man's” *tracks* Begg, Volume 1, “The Word of God, Not Men”

24%

of sermon words in reused regions
21% commentary · 3% shared Scripture

21%

of Begg's sermon reappears
1,219 of 5,840 words

8/10

reviewer dependence rating
order correlation $\rho = 0.49$

45%

estimated original material
reviewer estimate of the sermon

Begg's alliterated four-P outline (Process, Product, Persecution, Pronouncement) arrives with three headings word-for-word and the fourth renamed. The Leon Morris quotation, the “imitate Parkside Church” application with its four-item list, and the closing prayer all transfer. The preacher's own contribution is a 13-minute expansion of Begg's two-sentence point about a praying congregation.

Outline comparison

Same skeleton. Both sermons run on an identical alliterated four-point frame announced the same way — Begg: 'I have a number of points this evening, all that begin with the [letter] P'; FBC: 'I've got four points to make that begin with the letter P' — and the first three headings are word-for-word the same (Process, Product, Persecution) in the same order, arriving in the same sequence of sub-moves (prepositions → Leon Morris → praying congregation → 'many, many churches' → James, does not hearers → imitators of Judea → 'what would they find as ...

What is the pastor's own

The FBC preacher's substantial original contribution is concentrated in one place: Begg devotes two sentences to 'the absolute necessity of an expectant praying congregation', and the FBC preacher expands that into roughly thirteen minutes (1:05:46-1:19:20) of wholly independent material — a NextGen classroom anecdote, a Spurgeon 'furnace room' illustration interleaved with a 'the night the power went out' story, a week-by-week prayer plan mapped onto the ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 1:02:40

“Leon Morris who's a 20th century theologian has a very helpful thought in this uh of his observations. He said, "Paul could preach with certainty and power, for he had the profound conviction that what he said was not of man's devising ...”

Same scholar, same sentence, same slot in the argument, same introductory formula. The only change is that Begg's 'comment... in his commentary' becomes 'a very helpful ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“Leon Morris has a very helpful comment on this as he addresses this in his commentary. And he says Paul could preach with certainty and power for he had the profound conviction that what he said was not of man's devising, but in very truth ...”

FBC TUCSON 1:20:52

“If people came from other churches to find out what we're doing and what we're all about, what would we model for them to imitate as a church? What would they find was distinctive hallmarks of our church family? ... they learned how to be ...”

The sermon's central application, including a four-item list in identical order, with Begg's church name swapped for the local one. Not Scripture and not generic.

ALISTAIR BEGG

“if people came from other churches to imitate Parkside Church, what would we give them to imitate? ... What would they find as the kind of distinctive hallmarks of our church family? ... It would be wonderful to think that they learned ...”

FBC TUCSON 1:30:33

“we pray that you would make us zealous for the gospel. And we recognize so much confusion abounds in our schools and universities and the thorough affairs of our lives. And it's hard to engage people. In fact, the task is so daunting it ...”

The extemporaneous-sounding closing prayer is reproduced almost word for word, including the rare phrase 'thoroughfares of our lives' (captioned at FBC as 'thorough affairs').

ALISTAIR BEGG

“you will make a zealous for the gospel... so much confusion abounds in our schools and universities in the thoroughfares of our lives it's hard to engage people in fact the task is so daunting it drives us to our knees bring us to our ...”

Sermon body 0:57:33–1:31:14 of the livestream (34 min, 5,499 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

SERMON PROFILE 4 OF 6 · MAY 31, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 2:17-20

“Our Glory and Joy” *tracks* Begg, Volume 1, “Our Glory and Joy”

39%	41%	9/10	35%
of sermon words in reused regions	of Begg's sermon reappears	reviewer dependence rating	estimated original material
37% commentary · 2% shared Scripture	1,630 of 4,021 words	order correlation $\rho = 0.66$	reviewer estimate of the sermon

Begg’s “source, force and course” outline, his opening prayer over the text, his Greek word study, his commentaries aside, his only named authority (John Stott, with Begg’s words of introduction) and his three-question peroration are all present in Begg’s order. The FBC additions are illustrations and call-and-response.

Outline comparison

Same skeleton, same sequence, and largely the same sentences. The FBC sermon follows Begg's three-point alliteration ('the source, the force and the course'), his order of supporting texts (2 Thess 2:13-15, Rom 8:28-30, Eph 2, then Phil 2:16, Phil 4:1, 1 Cor 9), his sub-moves (the 'brothers' key word, 'not superficial but substantial', 'the ground is flat at the foot of the cross', the Greek 'orphan' word, the commentaries aside, the Stott quotation, the athlete's crown, the 'tomorrow morning, loved ones' charge) and even his closing recap verbatim. The ...

What is the pastor's own

The FBC preacher supplies his own delivery layer: a stand-up opening, congregational call-and-response, on-screen family photo, and a full set of substitute illustrations. Every one of Begg's set-piece illustrations and quotations is dropped (Chrysostom twice, John Stott's 'he felt and acted towards them as if they were his own children', the hymn 'only a sinner saved by grace', the honeymoon departure on a Russian ship and the father-in-law's shaking ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 0:59:37 “So, what do we do with that? I found John Stodd, a great theologian, so helpful because here's what he says about this. Since we lack this information, it's better for us to confess our ignorance than to express an unwarranted confidence. ...” The sermon's only named authority, plus the words of introduction and the follow-on sentence, come to FBC through Begg. The mispronunciation 'John Stodd' suggests it was ...	ALISTAIR BEGG “again I found John Stark to be so helpful will he said since we lack this information it is better for us to confess our ignorance than to express an unwarranted confidence the details will get in heaven”
FBC TUCSON 1:05:04 “And that's why he labored. He talks about it in 1 Corinthians chapter 9. It took me a while to dig up this phrase in Paul's life, but 1 Corinthians 9:19 says, "Though I am free and belong to no man, I make myself a slave to anyone to win ...” Begg's 'this little driving phrase in Paul's life' becomes a claim of personal research - 'it took me a while to dig up this phrase in Paul's life' - attached to the same ...	ALISTAIR BEGG “you see that is why we labored hard in first Corinthians 9 to notice this little driving phrase in Paul's life though I am free and belong to no man I make myself a slave to everyone to win as many as possible”
FBC TUCSON 0:50:58 “issues of intellect and absence of the same, the matters of race a and racial prejudice, those things, the matters of the right and the left of politics, God says they're all neutralized at the foot of the cross.” A near-verbatim list ('issues of intellect or absence of the same... matters of race... are all neutralized') with one item swapped out for a 2026 American item ('the right ...	ALISTAIR BEGG “The issues of intellect or absence of the same, the issues of substance and financial provision or its absence, the matters of race and prior affections and concerns are all neutralized when the family of God begins to understand...”

Sermon body 0:39:34–1:09:55 of the livestream (30 min, 4,679 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

SERMON PROFILE 5 OF 6 · JUNE 28, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 4:1-8

“Sexual Purity” *tracks* Begg, Volume 2, “Sexual Purity, Part One” (with Part Two)

10%

of sermon words in reused regions
9% commentary · 2% shared Scripture

13%

of Begg’s sermon reappears
595 of 4,747 words

7/10

reviewer dependence rating
order correlation $p = 0.89$

50%

estimated original material
reviewer estimate of the sermon

The lowest token overlap in the series, but the reviewer judged the machine figure a floor: the sermon’s organising device, reading 1 Thessalonians 4:3-8 as one half of a conversation, is Begg’s, run with the same objections in the same order for about twenty minutes. Roughly half the clock is genuinely the preacher’s own autobiography and dating counsel.

Outline comparison

Partly the same skeleton, and the shared part is the expository spine. The FBC sermon opens and closes with material that is entirely its own (Norm Wright, the seminary-summer story, the Honda Accord, Babylon/public schools), but the moment it turns to the text at 0:46:54 it follows Begg’s Part One almost step for step: the same three proof texts in the same order (John 8, 2 Cor 5, Eph 5:10), the same thesis sentence about aspirations and the praise of his glory, the same ‘do we have the right to be so bold and forceful’ objection, the same ...

What is the pastor’s own

Roughly half the sermon by clock time is the FBC preacher’s own, and it is genuinely his: two long autobiographical narratives, a controlling visual metaphor he brought from his own previous week, a distinctive pedagogical frame (equipping parents and grandparents to have this conversation), and a set of blunt local applications about dating that have no counterpart in Begg. He is also a different kind of preacher — anecdotal, Americanised, politically ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 0:48:21

“God does not exist to serve us. We exist to serve him. He doesn’t exist in order that he might fulfill our aspirations, but we exist in order that we might live to the praise of his glory.”

The sermon’s thesis sentence, delivered as ‘here it is in a nutshell’, is Begg’s sentence verbatim from the second word onward. Not Scripture, not a stock phrase — the ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“God does not exist for us, but we exist for him. He does not exist in order that he might fulfill our aspirations, but we exist in order that we might live to the praise of his glory.”

FBC TUCSON 1:11:22

“This means I got to spend 11 more years. 11 more years. I I don’t even have a girlfriend right now. I mean, if I met one, I don’t even know if she’d like me.”

An arbitrary number and a throwaway joke, both reproduced. Nothing in the FBC sermon’s own setup generates the figure ‘eleven’; it is inherited from Begg’s hypothetical ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“I’m supposed to live in purity, says the teenager ... I don’t even have a girlfriend. If I met one, I don’t know if she’d like me ... This may be for the next 11 years.”

FBC TUCSON 1:15:13

“So, let’s put it this way. When things are evil, the Christian attitude is not to be one of moderation, but it’s to be abstinence.”

A named commentator’s sentence in Begg becomes the FBC preacher’s own summing-up; even the introducing verb survives, with ‘Marshall puts it in this way’ turning into ‘let’s ...

ALISTAIR BEGG

“Marshall puts it in this way where things are evil, the Christian attitude is necessarily one of abstinence and not of moderation.”

Sermon body 0:38:28–1:18:03 of the livestream (40 min, 6,225 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

SERMON PROFILE 6 OF 6 · JULY 26, 2026 · 1 THESSALONIANS 5:23-24

“The Faithfulness of God” *tracks* Begg, Volume 3, “The Faithfulness of God”

36%	36%	9/10	35%
of sermon words in reused regions	of Begg's sermon reappears	reviewer dependence rating	estimated original material
35% commentary · 1% shared Scripture	1,689 of 4,749 words	order correlation $p = 0.49$	reviewer estimate of the sermon

A re-preached manuscript: the hapax word study and Thessalonian tombstones, the pivot to Romans 8, the Westminster Confession line, the Packer list and the final take-home (“carve that into your mind ... God is for me”) all arrive in order. Begg’s first-person confession about his own week is preached as the FBC pastor’s own.

Outline comparison

Same skeleton, lightly reordered and re-verbed. Both men take 1 Thessalonians 5:23-24, work the identical sequence inside it (the rare word 'blameless at his coming' and the Thessalonian tombstones, 1 John 3:2, Philippians 1:6, Zinzendorf's two hymn stanzas, the 'what/how question', verse 24 answered in the Phillips translation, 'God is not the author of unfinished business'), then make the same pivot — 'how can we be sure of this? Turn to this great chapter,' Romans 8 — and run the same 'no condemnation to no separation' frame, the same Romans 1-5 ...

What is the pastor’s own

The FBC preacher supplies his own opening (a run of 'daily grind' images and a personal photograph), his own illustrations in most of the slots where Begg had illustrations, congregational interaction, and his own closing prayer. Crucially, ALL of his substitutions sit inside Begg's frame: they decorate Begg's points, they never generate a point. Where Begg has Augustus Toplady's hymn twice, the dandelion 'he loves me, he loves me not', Psalm 84:11, 1 ...

Side by side

FBC TUCSON 0:56:23 “And that's been true this week. At least for me, it's been very true this week that I haven't done all the good that I long to do. And that somehow I've managed to distance myself from evil that I should have renounced, whether I did it or ...” Begg's own week, Begg's own confession, preached as the FBC pastor's week and confession. The dropped negation ('nor have I managed' becomes 'somehow I've managed') inverts ...	ALISTAIR BEGG “And that's been true this week. It has for me. I have not lived and done all the good for which I longed, nor have I managed to distance myself from the evil I should have renounced.”
FBC TUCSON 1:01:01 “Jer put it so eloquently in describing this. The Christian troubled by the memory of a moral lapse. The Christian whose integrity just cost him a friend or a job. The Christian whose children are disappointing her. The Christian who's made ...” A five-item J.I. Packer list in identical order with the identical unexplained gender switch on item three, introduced with Begg's exact verb phrase. FBC stops precisely ...	ALISTAIR BEGG “Now Packard puts it so eloquently in describing these scenes when he says, here is the Christian troubled by the memory of a moral lapse. The Christian whose integrity has lost him a friend or a job. The Christian parent whose children are ...”
FBC TUCSON 1:13:33 “Here's the simple application. If God is for me, carve that into your mind today. Repeat it tonight. ... One thing I know for sure, God is for you and he's for me.” The final take-home line of both sermons, same verb ('carve'), same phrase, same placement. Borrowing the conclusion is stronger evidence than borrowing the middle.	ALISTAIR BEGG “If you get nothing else out of today, get that little phrase from verse 31 and carve it into your recollection as you begin tomorrow morning ... say this to yourself, well I know one thing for sure, God is for me.”

Sermon body 0:43:23–1:15:20 of the livestream (32 min, 4,665 words). Quotations are verbatim from the auto-captions and Whisper transcripts, so proper nouns may be garbled (“John Stodd” = John Stott). Full region list with timestamps: analysis/out/alignments/.

The control: two other FBC preachers on the same book share only Scripture with Begg

The series is not a one-preacher series. Two of the nine recordings were preached by other FBC staff, on passages Begg also preached (Volume 2, Parts 1–3; Volume 3, tracks 1–9). They went through exactly the same detector and the same full-transcript review. Both came back at 0% commentary overlap and a dependence rating of 0. This is what independent preaching on the same verses looks like, and it is the yardstick against which the senior pastor's six sermons should be read.

"Your True Identity" · July 12, 2026 · 1 Thessalonians 5:1-11

Preacher: The preacher is NOT the lead pastor. He is an unnamed teaching elder/associate who preaches in rotation: he says 'Pastor Pat covered that last week' [00:50:01] and again 'chapter 4 that Pastor Pat spoke on last week' [01:02:29], and 'the last time I spoke to ...

This sermon is genuinely independent of Begg and is the cleanest internal control in the corpus. The machine alignment is empty and my own seven-word n-gram scan of the sermon window against all twenty-two Begg transcripts produces only Scripture matches - 1 Thess 4:16-17, 5:2, 5:5, 5:9-11 - which is exactly what two preachers reading the same passage should produce and is not evidence of anything. The two men are not even using the same translation: FBC reads the NASB ('as to the times and the epochs, brethren'), Begg the NIV ('about times and dates... brothers'), so a preacher working from Begg's manuscript would have had to re-key every quotation. Every load-bearing illustration is different and, more tellingly, Begg's most memorable ones are missing precisely where a dependent sermon would have used them: at verse 8 Begg spends four minutes on the motorbike helmet and returns to it ...

"The Walk of Influence" · July 19, 2026 · 1 Thessalonians 5:12-22

Preacher: Preacher self-identifies at 0:41:47: "Hey, it is great to be with you this morning. U, I'm Pastor Kevin if we haven't met." He preaches SEATED and jokes about it (0:41:29 "Do you guys mind me sitting? ... don't get me wrong, I'm really happy that I can stand ...

This sermon is independent of Alistair Begg. The machine alignment found no paired source above threshold, and a direct 5-gram comparison of the sermon window (5,269 tokens) against all 22 Begg transcripts returns only Scripture and dead-generic filler: the longest shared strings anywhere in the corpus are 'give thanks in all circumstances', 'this is God's will for you in Christ Jesus', 'live in peace with one another' and 'in love because of their work' -- i.e. 1 Thessalonians 5:13-18 itself, which both men read aloud, plus phrases like 'read the word of God' and 'I want to do it'. Targeted greps for the sermon's distinctive load-bearing material (Simon Sinek / 'start with the why' / 'elevating yourself'; perissos; Ephesians 3:20 'far more abundantly'; Strong's / propheta; 'prophetic utterance'; the Bereans of Acts 17 used as a testing model; James 1 'consider it all joy'; Romans 5 ...

Excluded recording: "Big Mess" (August 1, 2026). NOT a Sunday sermon and NOT the main preacher. This is a children's ministry event ('Big Mess') held Saturday 2026-08-01 (all other playlist items are Sunday services; 080226 is the Sunday). Two hosts share the mic. The male host self-identifies at [00:15:08.839]: 'I am Brian. I am the family ministry director here at ... It contains no sermon on 1 Thessalonians and no Begg material, and is excluded from all sermon-level statistics.

Even the sermon titles are Begg’s, including three recordings we could not transcribe

Of the 17 titled Sunday recordings in the playlist, nine (under eight titles) carry a title identical or near-identical to a Begg sermon in the 22-sermon comparison corpus. Six of the nine are the sermons analysed above. The other three, the April 12 “Faith, Hope and Love”, “Truth and Love” and “Living to Please God”, have captions disabled and could not be checked, but their titles match Begg’s Volume 1 tracks 1 and 5 and Volume 2 track 1. The six remaining untranscribed titles could not be compared: the Begg volumes contain sermons that are not in the local corpus, and the publisher’s site was unreachable from this environment.

FBC TUCSON VIDEO (2026)	NEAREST ALISTAIR BEGG TITLE	TITLE MATCH	STATUS
Faith, Hope and Love (Apr 12 and Apr 19)	Faith, Hope and Love (Vol. 1)	identical	Apr 19 analysed: 20% reused · Apr 12: captions disabled
The Secret Place (Apr 26)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled
Chosen and Changed (May 3)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled
No Clever Tricks (May 10)	No Clever Tricks (Vol. 1)	identical	40% reused
Truth and Love (May 17)	Truth and Love (Vol. 1)	identical	captions disabled; not analysed
God’s Word... Not Man’s (May 24)	The Word of God, Not Men (Vol. 1)	near-identical	24% reused
Our Glory and Joy (May 31)	Our Glory and Joy (Vol. 1)	identical	39% reused
The Inevitable Affliction (Jun 7)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled
Abound in Love (Jun 14)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled
Living to Please God (Jun 21)	Pleasing God (Vol. 2)	near-identical	captions disabled; not analysed
Sexual Purity (Jun 28)	Sexual Purity, Parts One and Two (Vol. 2)	identical	10% reused
About Date and Time (Jul 5)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled
Your True Identity (Jul 12)	The Coming of the Lord, Part Three (Vol. 2)	different	0% · other preacher
The Walk of Influence (Jul 19)	Learning to Respect Our Leadership ... Do Not Grieve the Holy Spirit (Vol. 3)	different	0% · Pastor Kevin
The Faithfulness of God (Jul 26)	The Faithfulness of God (Vol. 3)	identical	36% reused
Attitudes of a Healthy Church (Aug 2)	—	not in local corpus	captions disabled

Source: playlist.json (25 entries: 17 titled Sunday recordings, 1 children’s event, 7 removed videos). Title comparison against the 22 locally transcribed Begg sermons only.

Implication. The six analysed sermons are the ones whose captions happened to be enabled. Nothing in the pattern suggests they are unrepresentative: the three untranscribed recordings whose titles can be checked also carry Begg’s titles, and the senior pastor’s 1 Thessalonians preaching in this playlist runs from April through late July. Obtaining audio for the caption-disabled videos would allow the same analysis to be completed for the series as a whole.

Methodology and limitations

Corpus

FBC Tucson: the 9 videos in the “A Church of Irresistible Influence” playlist that have YouTube auto-captions (16 of 25 entries had captions disabled or were removed). Captions were downloaded with youtube-transcript-api and keep per-line timestamps. Alistair Begg: the 22 sermons of Truth For Life’s *A Study in 1 Thessalonians*, Volumes 1–3, transcribed locally with Whisper from the public audio.

Normalisation

Lower-case; punctuation, caption tags and speaker markers removed; contractions collapsed; spelled-out numbers to digits; British spellings and a dozen ASR variants (“Thessalonika”, “gonna”) mapped to one form.

Detection

Exact runs. Maximal runs of identical tokens of ≥ 8 words (the earlier report’s measure) and ≥ 5 words.

Reused regions. Exact 4-word seeds (excluding 4-grams occurring >12 times in the source) are chained when consecutive seeds lie within 40 words and 25 positions of the same diagonal; the chained span is re-scored with a token-level sequence matcher and kept if ≥ 12 words and $\geq 45\%$ identity. Overlapping regions are merged. This recovers passages that caption errors and light paraphrase break into fragments.

Pairing. A Begg sermon is “paired” when $\geq 4\%$ of the FBC transcript falls inside reused regions with it. Coverage is the union over paired sources, so overlapping regions are not double-counted.

Sermon body

Start and end timestamps were set by the reviewer after reading each transcript (first words of the sermon proper to the end of the closing prayer). Percentages in Exhibits 1, 4 and 6 and in the profiles use this denominator; the heat map and baselines use the whole transcript so that all 22 sources are comparable.

Scripture handling

A heuristic flagged regions as likely Scripture using fuzzy overlap with public-domain translations (KJV, BBE), quotation cues (“verse 6”), and recurrence across ≥ 2 other Begg sermons. Because both preachers read the NIV, which is not public domain, the heuristic under-flags; the reviewer therefore classified every one of the 151 regions by hand as Scripture, commentary or mixed, and the final figures use those labels. Mixed regions count as commentary.

Close reading

Each FBC transcript and its paired Begg transcript(s) were read in full by an independent large-language-model reviewer (Claude Opus 5), separately for each sermon, with instructions to quote captions verbatim with timestamps, to discount Scripture and stock evangelical phrasing, to search all 22 Begg transcripts for the FBC sermon’s distinctive phrases, and to rate dependence from 0 to 10. Outputs are structured JSON in analysis/out/reviews/ and were spot-checked against the alignments.

Baselines

The same detector was run on all 231 Begg-vs-Begg pairs (a preacher’s normal self-repetition) and all 170 FBC-vs-non-paired-Begg pairs (two preachers on related texts).

Limitations

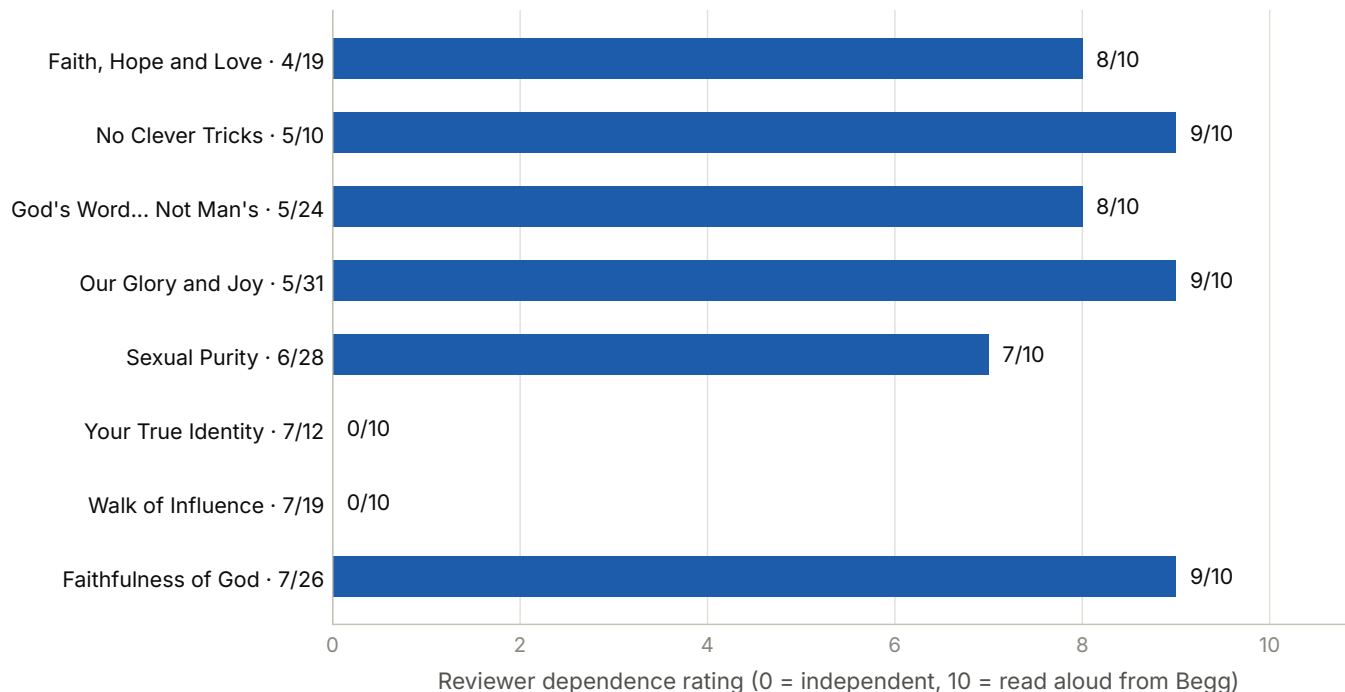
- Both texts are machine transcripts. Errors lower identity scores and can occasionally create false matches; the reviewer verified every quoted passage in context.
- Coverage figures are floors. Structural borrowing (an outline, a dialogue device) and heavy paraphrase are invisible to token alignment and appear only in the qualitative findings.
- Only 6 of the senior pastor’s sermons in the series had captions; the remainder could not be analysed.
- Transcripts show what was said, not intent, permission or the preacher’s own view of his practice. Truth For Life’s usage terms were not reviewed.
- Reproducible code: analysis/analyze.py, finalize.py, charts.py, build_report.py.

Appendix A · Sermon-level data

FBC SERMON	DATE	PASSAGE	SERMON BODY	WORDS	PAIRED BEGG SERMON	REUSED	COMMENTARY	EXACT-8	OF BEGG	P	RATING
Faith, Hope and Love	April 19	1 Thess. 1:1-3	0:34:14–1:18:35	6,656	Faith, Hope and Love	20.5%	18.9%	5.5%	20%	0.88	8
No Clever Tricks	May 10	1 Thess. 2:1-8	0:49:12–1:21:22	5,196	No Clever Tricks	40.4%	37.0%	10.7%	43%	0.64	9
God's Word... Not Man's	May 24	1 Thess. 2:13-16	0:57:33–1:31:14	5,499	The Word of God, Not Men	23.7%	21.2%	9.1%	21%	0.49	8
Our Glory and Joy	May 31	1 Thess. 2:17-20	0:39:34–1:09:55	4,679	Our Glory and Joy	39.4%	36.9%	12.3%	41%	0.66	9
Sexual Purity	June 28	1 Thess. 4:1-8	0:38:28–1:18:03	6,225	Sexual Purity, Part One	10.5%	8.8%	3.3%	13%	0.89	7
Your True Identity	July 12	1 Thess. 5:1-11	0:42:55–1:14:01	4,402	—	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	—	—	0
The Walk of Influence	July 19	1 Thess. 5:12-22	0:41:24–1:22:20	5,336	—	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	—	—	0
The Faithfulness of God	July 26	1 Thess. 5:23-24	0:43:23–1:15:20	4,665	The Faithfulness of God	35.9%	34.9%	12.9%	36%	0.49	9

Reused = share of sermon-body words inside any reused region. Commentary = the same after removing reviewer-classified Scripture. Exact-8 = share inside unbroken 8-word exact runs (earlier report's measure, sermon-body basis). Of Begg = share of the paired Begg sermon's words that reappear. ρ = Spearman rank correlation of reused-region positions. Rating = reviewer dependence rating, 0–10.

EXHIBIT 8 Reviewer dependence ratings, by sermon



Source: analysis/out/reviews/*.json. Rating scale: 0 = independent treatment of the passage; 10 = Begg's manuscript read aloud.

Appendix B · The eleven longest reused commentary passages

FBC SERMON	TIME	WORDS	IDENTITY	FBC TUCSON (NORMALISED CAPTIONS, OPENING)	ALISTAIR BEGG (NORMALISED TRANSCRIPT, OPENING)
The Faithfulness of God	0:50:04	361	68%	who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of jesus christ count ludri von zeninsorf a great 18th century himwriter pondered this truth and ...	who has begun a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of jesus christ zinsendorf the great hymn writer in pondering this immense truth in 1 of his ...
God's Word... Not Man's	1:26:12	280	56%	especially coming from a jew paul towards other jews his own brothers remember paul was jewish paul was fiercely jewish and so to set the record straight now heres ...	especially coming from a jew because remember that paul was jewish paul was fiercely jewish paul even after his conversion was not about to cast aspersions on all ...
No Clever Tricks	1:04:12	261	50%	and then 3 our methods are not the kinds of fraudulent stuff that you see in the itinerant vagrants that are out there and then he says if you really want to ...	and thirdly our methods are not the kind of fraudulent stuff that you see on the other itinerant vagrants we did not stoop to offering fraudulent blessings nor did ...
No Clever Tricks	0:51:12	247	65%	us with perhaps the most touching glimpse to the heart of the apostle paul as to the influence of a mother thats given anywhere in all of scripture you know if we ...	us with probably the most touching glimpse into the heart of the apostle paul that is given anywhere in all of scripture if we were prepared to say that the book of ...
Our Glory and Joy	0:40:02	224	61%	to pour out verse 17 but brothers when we were torn away from you for a short time in person but not in thought out of our intense longing we made every effort to ...	to verse 17 but brothers when we were torn away from you for a short time in person not in thought out of our intense longing we made every effort to see you for we ...
Faith, Hope and Love	1:10:26	186	52%	love is called the agape love of god its the love that costs god his only son its a love that becomes active after the cross of his son its a love which remains a ...	love here is the agape love of god which was a love that cost god his son it was a love that was active in the cross of his son and it was and remains a love which ...
Sexual Purity	1:12:33	186	48%	people who have been separated from him and all that past which marked your previous existence he wants you to be separated from that and now separated to him now ...	people who have been separated from all that marked our previous existence and separated too if you think about it in terms of marriage youve got it before you were ...
God's Word... Not Man's	1:22:21	179	50%	pauls 1 century opponents in the preaching of the gospel were jewish and not only that but they pursued him to thessalonica and then when he went to berea they ...	pauls opponents in the preaching of the gospel were jewish and they pursued him to thessalonica and then when he went to athens they pursued him to burya and when ...
No Clever Tricks	1:01:29	177	44%	now in addressing himself in this way what paul is doing is hes distancing himself from the many vagrants all of the the the halaloo of people who have been working ...	now in addressing himself in this way paul is distancing himself from the many itinerant vagrants whom he also knew had been working the crowds let me quote from 1 ...
No Clever Tricks	1:03:07	176	47%	i want you to understand for the sake of the gospel and for the church the f the future of this church i want you to know 3 things that our message is true our ...	i want you to understand for the sake of the gospel and the future of the church i want you to understand 3 things number 1 our message is true number 2 our methods ...
The Faithfulness of God	1:04:48	175	55%	if god is for us nothing else really matters its true for you this morning if youre in jesus christ whether youre actually facing whatever might be to you an ...	if god is for us who can be against us there my dear friends is 1 of the great 4 words statements of the whole of the bible and it is true tonight concerning you if ...

Regions are shown lower-cased and stripped of punctuation as the detector sees them; only the opening of each region is printed. The complete list of 115 commentary regions and 36 Scripture regions, with both texts in full, is in analysis/out/alignments/ and analysis/out/results_final.json.